



Brains behind the brawn: Nadal with his first coach, uncle Toni, and his last coach, Carlos Moya.

He celebrated winners with leaping uppercut fist pumps and cries of “Vamos!” His body language projected hyper-confidence that intimidated opponents as much as his dynamic athleticism and jaw-dropping shots.

After the Spanish matador slew the bull for almost all of his 22 Grand Slam titles, he celebrated in ecstasy by collapsing on the court — either to his knees, pumping his arms with a last spasm of energy, or on his back in exhaustion.

And yet Rafael Nadal Parera, nicknamed ‘Rafa’, was a bundle of contradictions that endeared him even more to his admirers worldwide. In his 2011 memoir, *RAFA*, his mother, Ana Maria Parera, explained, “He’s on top in the tennis world but, deep down, he is a super-sensitive human being full of fears and insecurities that people who don’t

know him would scarcely imagine.” More than any champion in tennis history, Nadal exemplified the Greek philosopher Heraclitus’s aphorism — ‘Character is destiny’.

Let’s look back at highlights of the life and times of this sporting immortal.

Family matters

Toni Nadal coached his nephew from the age of 4 to 28 without payment. Toni is as proud of Nadal’s gracious acknowledgements after press conferences and the fact that he never broke his racket in anger as he is of his many Grand Slam titles and all-time records.

Nadal remained humble and gracious, always praising his opponents both in victory and defeat — and sometimes even consoling them, as he did with a weeping Roger Federer after their riveting 2009 Australian Open final.

Asked by *Tennis Channel* in 2011 when he realised he was special, Nadal’s answer was as simple as it

was humble: “Never.”

In his memoir, he wrote: “There was fun and magic in my relationship with Toni, even if the prevailing mood when we trained was stony and severe. And we had plenty of success.”

Toni whacked tennis balls near him to scare him when he wasn’t paying attention, made him (and not the other kids) sweep the courts, ridiculed him as “mummy’s boy”, and seldom celebrated his victories. Sometimes the little boy came home crying, which distressed his mother.

As a teenager, Nadal called his mother every night while on tour, and well into his 20s, he contacted his sister, Maribel, multiple times in a day by phone or online.

The third woman in his life is Maria Francisca (Mery) Perelló, his girlfriend since 2005 whom he married in 2019. Mery gave birth to their son, also named Rafael, on October 8, 2022.

This extremely low-profile, private trio — especially his mother — created a safe haven for one of the